

CASE-05

# Budget tracking tells you that you overspent. Wrong tense.

A product case for an AI budget layer inside a project management tool — scored down to an MVP with RICE, and an interface critique attached.

SELF-DIRECTED CASE STUDY

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Product thinking · RICE prioritisation · Interface critique

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# Three users, one complaint, three tenses.

Project managers and finance teams operate reactively: financial decisions get made on incomplete information, and overruns are **discovered rather than prevented**.

The project manager wants to predict, not track. Finance wants anomalies surfaced, not hunted. Operations wants to know what a spend does to the timeline **before** committing it.

The baseline is measurable and nobody was measuring it: share of projects over budget, reconciliation time per project, the lag between an expense occurring and being recognised, and the real cost of overruns.

Scored with RICE

FEATURES SCORED

**7**

TOP SCORE

**6.75**

HIGHEST-IMPACT FEATURE

**0.90**

# The obvious build versus the right build.

Two features on the same list. One is the reason you'd build the product. The other is the reason it ships.

## AI-POWERED EXPENSE MATCHING

The highest impact score on the board — and an effort of 10, needing OCR, model training and accuracy handling. RICE 0.90.

## INLINE BUDGET ANNOTATIONS

Unglamorous, invisible in a demo, effort of 2. RICE 6.75 — roughly seven times higher.

Scoring the full set forced the MVP to become annotations, predictive burn-rate alerts and contextual anomaly detection — **none of which is the feature I'd have led with** if I'd trusted my instinct instead of the arithmetic.

# What I decided, and why.

## **1 • Let the scoring override taste**

All seven features scored on reach, impact, confidence and effort — and the MVP taken from the top of the list, not from the top of my preferences.

## **2 • Push commitment tracking to phase two**

It's genuinely valuable for a true financial picture, but it depends on external procurement integrations. Integration risk is not MVP risk.

## **3 • Treat the interface critique as MVP scope**

Inline form to modal, standardised KPI cards, and a budget-versus-actual chart with two colours and a legend. Predictions nobody can read aren't predictions.

## **4 • Name the risks with mitigations attached**

Model bias, over-reliance on automation, cognitive overload, and resistance to recommendations — each paired with a specific countermeasure rather than a caveat.

# I put the least impressive feature at the top of the MVP.

Inline annotations are not why anyone would buy this product, and they would not survive thirty seconds of a pitch. They also unblock the collaboration problem immediately, at a fifth of the cost of anything else on the list.

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What I took from it

RICE is only useful if you're willing to be embarrassed by the answer. The feature I most wanted to demo scored last. The one I'd never put in a deck scored first — and it was right.

Happy to talk through the thinking —  
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